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[GS PAPER II – GOVERNANCE • GS PAPER III – INDIAN ECONOMY] | **Publication Date: 21/09/2026**

Why Apple Faces CCPA Probe over User-Rights Issue



The CCPA's probe into Apple examines whether software-related issues and warranty exclusions could unfairly shift repair costs onto consumers. The case highlights consumer rights, warranty obligations and regulation of unfair trade practices.

Why Apple Faces CCPA Probe over User-Rights Issue

Syllabus Areas:

GS Paper II – Governance

GS Paper III – Indian Economy

The **Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA)** is investigating **Apple's software warranty terms** following complaints about problems allegedly experienced by users after the rollout of **iOS 18**.

The **Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA)** is India's consumer protection regulator, established under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, to safeguard consumer rights and address unfair trade practices.

Apple's software warranty terms generally exclude software-related damage, including issues caused by iOS updates, while hardware defects may remain covered under standard warranty provisions.

The issue concerns whether consumers should bear repair costs when a software update is alleged to have triggered hardware-related problems, and whether Apple's warranty terms and repair practices could amount to an **unfair trade practice**.

What is the CCPA Investigating?

Apple began rolling out **iOS 18 in 2024**. Following the rollout, some users reported various problems, including:

- Green, pink or white lines appearing on displays
- Microphone and call failures
- Frozen screens
- Battery drain
- Touchscreen malfunctions
- Camera malfunctions

Some users also reported that they were asked to pay for repairs. Replacing an **iPhone 15 screen costs about Rs. 27,900**.

The CCPA is examining whether consumers should bear such costs when the alleged trigger was Apple's software. It is also examining whether the company's warranty terms and repair practices amount to an unfair trade practice.

The CCPA first issued Apple a notice in **2025** and has subsequently escalated the matter to its investigation wing.



Apple's Position

Apple is contesting the regulator's allegations. The company has stated that the case was based on **70 complaints** and has denied that iOS 18 has a systemic problem in India.

In its response dated **20 August**, Apple stated that the software had undergone stringent testing. It also noted that only around **11% of iPhones were still running iOS 18 as of June 2026**.

Apple has defended its software warranty terms, pointing out that its licence agreements state that the software is provided **without any warranty**.

The company has also stated that it would work with the regulator to provide clarity regarding how it responded to customers who reported problems with their iPhones.

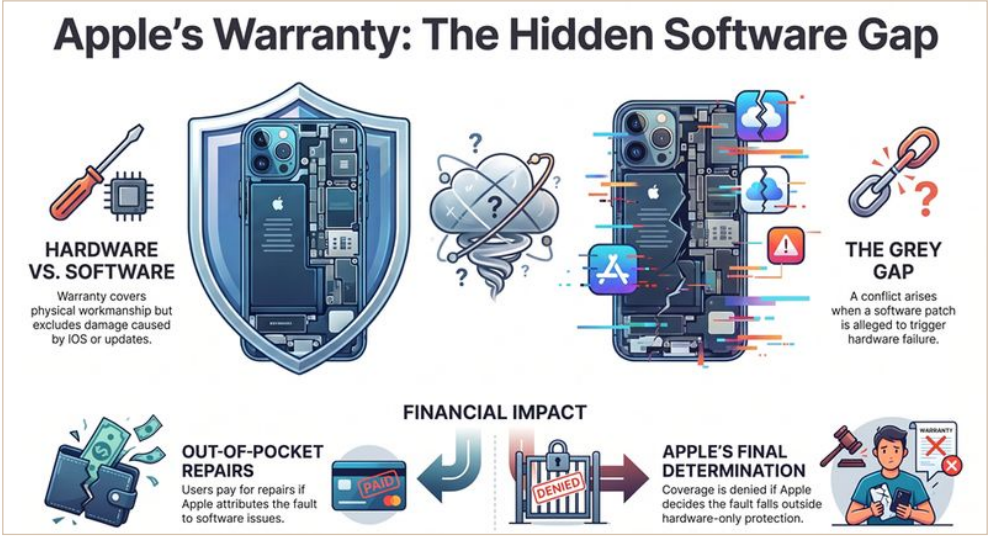


What is the Warranty Issue?

Apple's standard warranty covers defects in **materials and workmanship in the device's hardware**, but generally does not cover damage caused by iOS, including updates.

This creates a grey area when a software patch is alleged to have triggered a hardware problem.

In such cases, users may have to pay for repairs if Apple determines that the fault falls outside the scope of warranty coverage.



Can Consumer Law Override Warranty Terms?

A warranty is a contractual arrangement between a firm and a consumer. However, its terms do not automatically insulate a firm from its obligations under India's consumer protection laws.

The **Consumer Protection Act, 2019** empowers authorities to examine practices that may amount to unfair trade practices or may mislead consumers and to direct corrective action.

Although a warranty may specify the types of defects or repairs that Apple will cover, the CCPA can examine whether consumers were unfairly made to bear repair costs.



Implications for Other Companies

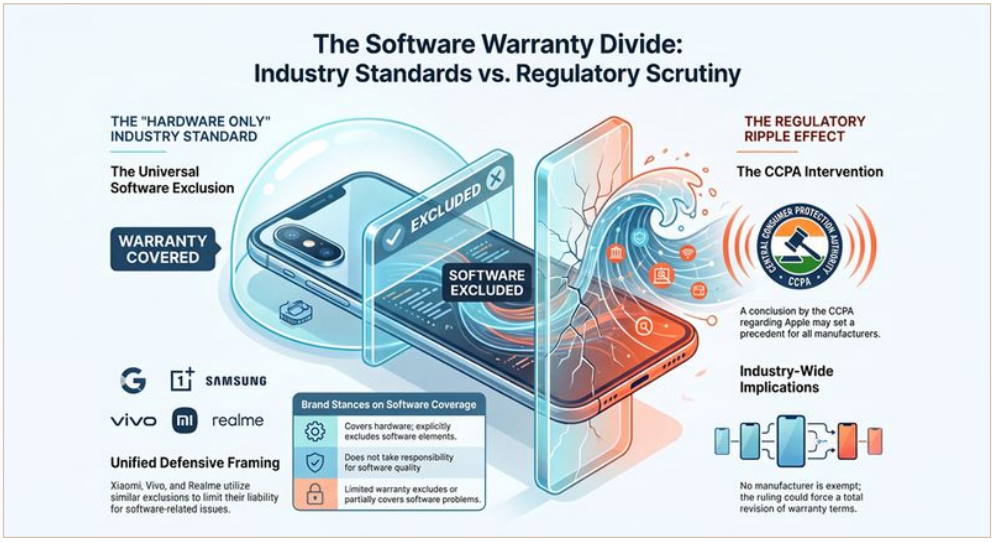
Apple is not the only company that distinguishes between hardware warranties and software.

Google's India warranty explicitly covers hardware and excludes software elements.

OnePlus states that its limited warranty does not cover, or only partially covers, software and excludes certain software-related problems.

Samsung's terms also state that it does not take responsibility for the quality of software.

Similarly, **Xiaomi, Vivo and Realme** frame their warranties with various exclusions.


The Software Warranty Divide:
Industry Standards vs. Regulatory Scrutiny
THE "HARDWARE ONLY" INDUSTRY STANDARD
The Universal Software Exclusion
WARRANTY COVERED
EXCLUDED
SOFTWARE EXCLUDED
SAMSUNG
vivo
realme
Unified Defensive Framing
Xiaomi, Vivo, and Realme utilize similar exclusions to limit their liability for software-related issues.
Brand Stances on Software Coverage
Covers hardware; explicitly excludes software elements.
Does not take responsibility for software quality
Limited warranty excludes or partially covers software problems.
THE REGULATORY RIPPLE EFFECT
The CCPA Intervention
CENTRAL CONSUMER PROTECTION AUTHORITY
CCPA
A conclusion by the CCPA regarding Apple may set a precedent for all manufacturers.
Industry-Wide Implications
No manufacturer is exempt; the ruling could force a total revision of warranty terms.